

the film in the editing studio. More than that, he's a team player, able to pull together a talented group of people, from music director Shantanu Moitra to lyricist Swanand Kirkire, from Joshi to his sound recordist Biswadeep Chatterjee. He's also a loyalist, refusing to switch from Chopra's side even when his first choice for the role of Rancho, Shah Rukh Khan, urged him to co-produce the movie with him.

Then there's Hirani's eye for detail. Whether it is the delivery scene in *3 Idiots* which made him consult gynaecologist Sejal Desai 15 times or sourcing the inventions from IIM-Ahmedabad Professor Anil Gupta's National Innovation Foundation, Hirani is very thorough on research. If for *Munnabhai MBBS*, the effort was to get the medical terminology right and for the bhai-meets-Bapu epic, *Lage Raho Munnabhai*, it was to access the considerable work on Mahatma Gandhi so as not to contradict facts, for *3 Idiots*, it went from understanding hostel life to picking up words from the IIT dictionary of slang. Each aspect of the film was carefully thought out, from the incidents of suicides to shooting the film in the grey-tinged IIM-Bangalore rather than the earthy-hued IIM-Ahmedabad so as not to let the backdrop overpower the characters.

The son of a typewriting institute proprietor from Nagpur who would repair calculators in his spare time and who can still type at a speed of 80 words a minute, Hirani is pretty much like one of his characters, the original rebel who did three years of commerce as well as one year of law before joining FTII as an editing student and throwing himself whole-heartedly into movies. Like Chatterjee, the sound designer on *3 Idiots*, whom he first met on the train going to Pune. Or Sriram Raghavan, the director in his unit who made the critically acclaimed *Ek Hasina Thi* and *Johnny Gaddaar*. He was Hirani's first rent-free landlord, with a house in Bangur Nagar, Mumbai, which privileged FTII graduates would treat as the gateway to Mumbai. Raghavan recalls those days, some of which he could glimpse in *3 Idiots*: "We bonded because of Hindi films. While other students were talking about Tarkovsky and Jansco, we'd be discussing *Qurbani*, *Shakti* and *Mard*." Hirani could see the film in his head, says Raghavan, and would always push him to do more. Twenty-three years on, nothing

The Idiom **MAKER**

As an editor, Rajkumar Hirani plays with images. But his skills as a wordsmith aren't too bad.

**MUNNABHAI MBBS AND
LAGE RAHO MUNNABHAI**

- He invented the *jadoo ki jhappi*, which the loveable rogue Munnabhai administered to everyone from recalcitrant sweepers to cancer-stricken young men.
- *Maamu*. That was how Circuit addressed everyone.
- *Wat lag gayi*. Even placards at the 2004 India-Pakistan cricket series held the legend aloft. Its polite English definition was "he's done for".
- *Lage Raho* made Gandhigiri a word and a way of life.



3 IDIOTS

- I had to break both my legs to stand on my own feet, says Sharman Joshi to the interview panel.
- Aal izz well.
- Don't be stupid. Be an idiot.
- Chase excellence, success will follow.
- *Jahanpanah*, *tussi great ho*.



seems to have changed.

In a universe marked by bling and baubles, Hirani lives a down-to-earth life with his Indian Airlines pilot wife Manjeet Lamba with whom he had an arranged marriage and his 11-year-old son Vir whose school he just changed because it did not observe non-Hindu festivals. It's a life that enables him to simply take off to the US or to Madh Island for writing sessions with Joshi, who teaches at the Ohio Wesleyan University for six months of the year, when the muse strikes him; to read Leftist Hindi writer Harishankar Parsai for inspiration; and to be oblivious to the temptation of easy work. It hasn't been easy though Hirani refuses to see it as a struggle.

Hirani still remembers selling his camera to pay for his first rented accommodation and spending his time in an editing studio, taking bookings, ordering food and organising the tea. He'd have done anything for movies, which he almost didn't end up making as he drifted into making ad films for a living after disastrous stints as editor in the never-completed Chandrachur Singh-starrer *Pyaar Kiya Toh Darna Kya* and the completed but wildly unsuccessful *Jasbaat* from Anant Balani. But then the idea of *Munnabhai* struck. He developed a script, took it to Chopra, the producer-director for whom he had edited the promos of *1942: A Love Story*. He had done the same for Chopra's next film, the disastrous *Kareeb*, written by a then 23-year-old Joshi before editing *Mission Kashmir*, when editing great and Chopra's ex-wife Renu Saluja died.

3 Idiots has not only made Hirani a much richer man as he will take home at least Rs 20 crore but it has also made him one of Bollywood's most phenomenal directors. It is likely that he will upgrade his car, a Honda Accord, and his home, currently in Bandra (East). But it is more likely that he will remain the guy who will share a bottle of whisky with the cast and crew of *3 Idiots* after watching the first print on the steps of the Adlabs preview theatre, who will wait patiently outside a small club after a function he's hosted because Joshi's car hadn't arrived, and who will always want to make films with a big heart and bigger mouth. He's one part Hrishikesh Mukherjee, one part Frank Capra, says Raghavan, and every part Dr Feel Good. ■